

- RAG Learning

2.5 Language Discourses

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Paper 2 Section B

This section is about **texts about language** — newspaper articles, opinion columns, blog posts, speeches — and how to analyse and evaluate them as *language discourses*. Paper 2 Section B requires you to analyse such texts and evaluate the arguments they make. The core tension is **prescriptivism vs descriptivism**, and the key theorists are **Aitchison, Crystal, Cameron** alongside prominent prescriptivists like **Truss** and **Humphrys**.

2.5.1 Prescriptivism vs Descriptivism

	Prescriptivism	Descriptivism
Aim	Say how language SHOULD be used	Describe how language IS used
Stance	Normative — deviations are errors	Scientific — all varieties are valid systems
Typical sources	Style guides, opinion columns, letters to the editor	Academic linguistics, corpus research, peer-reviewed work
Example figures	Swift, Johnson (partly), Truss, Humphrys, Heffer	Aitchison, Crystal, Cameron, Labov
Method	Anecdote, appeal to tradition, judgement	Data, corpus evidence, theory

Key distinction: linguistics as a discipline is descriptive. Style guides, editing and teaching inevitably involve some prescription — the key is whether claims about "correctness" are presented as LINGUISTIC facts (wrong) or STYLISTIC advice (legitimate).

2.5.2 Historical Prescriptivism

- **Jonathan Swift (1712)** — proposed establishing an English academy to "fix" the language.
- **Samuel Johnson (1755)** — *A Dictionary of the English Language* codified spelling and definitions. Partly prescriptive, partly descriptive. Johnson himself acknowledged that "no dictionary of a living tongue ever can be perfect".
- **18th-century grammarians** — imposed "rules" modelled on Latin (don't split infinitives, don't end sentences with prepositions, etc.). These rules don't reflect the natural grammar of English.
- **Lindley Murray's *English Grammar* (1795)** — hugely influential prescriptive schoolbook.

2.5.3 Contemporary Prescriptivists

- **Lynne Truss — *Eats, Shoots & Leaves* (2003)** — popular book on punctuation errors, written with humour but strongly normative.
- **John Humphrys** — broadcaster, newspaper columnist, decries "decline" of English.
- **Simon Heffer — *Strictly English* (2010)** — strict style advice presented as rules.
- **Nevile Gwynne — *Gwynne's Grammar* (2013)** — nostalgic, explicitly prescriptive.

2.5.4 Contemporary Descriptivists

- **David Crystal** — prolific writer (e.g. *The Stories of English*, *Txtng: The Gr8 Db8*). Views change as natural, digital innovation as added registers not decline.
- **Jean Aitchison** — Reith Lectures (1996), critiqued the "damp spoon", "crumbling castle", "infectious disease" metaphors.
- **Deborah Cameron** — *Verbal Hygiene* (1995), *The Myth of Mars and Venus* (2007) — analyses why language debates are often about social values, not linguistic facts.

2.5.5 Cameron's "Verbal Hygiene"

Deborah Cameron's concept of **verbal hygiene** describes the impulse to clean up, correct or regulate language. She argues this impulse is less about language than about *social values*:

- Grammar campaigns often reflect anxieties about discipline, standards and social change.
- Political-correctness debates concern values (inclusion, offence) as much as words.
- Plain-English movements reflect democratic values (accessibility).
- Sexist-language debates are about gender politics expressed linguistically.

Cameron's insight reframes language discourses as SYMBOLIC struggles: they are language discussions, but they are primarily about who we are and what we value.

2.5.6 Milroy's Standard Language Ideology

James and Lesley Milroy's concept of **standard language ideology** is the belief that there is ONE correct form of a language. This belief:

- Presupposes a single "correct" variety — usually the historically prestige form.
- Treats other varieties as imperfect versions.
- Is enforced via education, media, gatekeeping.
- Reflects the power of the social groups whose speech became the standard.

Standard language ideology is visible in language discourses whenever dialect speech is treated as error or regional accents as "bad". MLE being called "jafaican", AAVE being called "broken", a Yorkshire accent being called "lazy" — all are expressions of this ideology, not linguistic facts.

2.5.7 Sapir-Whorf — Linguistic Relativity

The Sapir-Whorf hypothesis argues that language shapes thought:

- **Strong version (linguistic determinism)** — language DETERMINES thought. Largely rejected.
- **Weak version (linguistic relativity)** — language INFLUENCES thought. Widely accepted; supported by experimental evidence (e.g. colour categorisation, spatial reasoning).

Relevant to language discourses because many prescriptive arguments presuppose a strong Whorfian claim: "if we use 'they' for singular, people will think less clearly". A descriptivist reply: the evidence does not support that strong claim.

2.5.8 Typical Rhetorical Features of Prescriptivist Texts

Feature	Function
Hyperbolic metaphor	"Battle", "war", "decay", "infection" — dramatises the stakes
Appeals to tradition	"This is how we've always done it" — authority by precedent
Personal anecdote	"I heard a shop assistant say..." — evidence by example
Inclusive "we"	Positions reader as fellow concerned citizen
Declarative certainty	Absence of hedging; claims presented as fact
Rhetorical questions	"Can we really let this happen?"
Classical allusion	Authority by association with tradition
Moral framing	"Laziness", "ignorance", "carelessness" — language issues become character issues

2.5.9 Typical Features of Descriptivist Texts

- Citation of research, data, historical evidence.
- Measured, hedged register.
- Acknowledgement of variation as normal.
- Contextualisation of complaints within historical recurrence.
- Analysis of WHY people worry about language, not just whether they are "right".

2.5.10 Common Language Discourse Topics

- **"Text speak is ruining English"** — rejected by Crystal's research; texters switch registers.
- **"Young people can't speak properly"** — a recurring moral panic in every generation.
- **"MLE / street slang is destroying the language"** — standard-language ideology dressed as linguistic claim.
- **"'Literally' as intensifier is wrong"** — a semantic shift with 18th-century precedents.
- **"Singular they is ungrammatical"** — factually wrong; attested since the 14th century.
- **"Political correctness has gone mad"** — usually a critique of lexis linked to social change (Cameron's verbal hygiene applies).
- **"Emoji are destroying written communication"** — Crystal and Tagg argue emoji add paralinguistic information absent in writing.

2.5.11 How to Analyse a Language Discourse Text

1. Identify the **claim**: what is the author arguing about language?
2. Identify the **stance**: prescriptivist, descriptivist, mixed?
3. Analyse **rhetorical features** — metaphor, presupposition, inclusive pronouns, register, evidence.
4. Analyse **linguistic choices** — lexis, grammar, graphology that construct the argument.
5. Consider the **audience** and its likely alignment.
6. **Evaluate** the claims in light of linguistic evidence — what would Crystal, Aitchison, Cameron say?
7. Link to the **social context** — what cultural anxieties does this discourse express?

Applied Example: A hypothetical column titled "Teenagers Can't Even Speak Properly Anymore" is likely to (a) presuppose a golden age, (b) use emotive verbs ("ruining", "butchering"), (c) invoke inclusive "we" positioning readers as concerned citizens, (d) cite anecdote not data, and (e) blame young people (moralising). A top-band analysis names each feature, applies Cameron's verbal hygiene to reframe the column as social anxiety, and cites Crystal's counter-evidence that educated young people switch registers competently.

2.5.12 Evaluating Language Discourses

A strong Paper 2 Section B answer:

1. Identifies rhetorical and linguistic techniques precisely.
2. Applies named theorists (Cameron, Crystal, Aitchison, Milroy).
3. Cites counter-evidence (corpus data, historical parallels, research).
4. Engages with the social context — why this discourse, why now?
5. Takes a clear evaluative stance without being dismissive.
6. Considers where the author's argument has merit, if any.

Exam Tip: Don't just dismiss prescriptivist articles as "wrong". Analyse HOW they construct their argument and engage critically with what they claim. Some prescriptive concerns (clarity in legal drafting, educational access to standard forms) have genuine merit; others are rhetorical moves dressed as linguistic facts. Distinguishing is what AO3 rewards.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define: **prescriptivism, descriptivism, Standard English, RP, golden age fallacy, verbal hygiene, standard language ideology, linguistic determinism / relativity (Sapir-Whorf), corpus linguistics, rhetorical features (metaphor, presupposition, rhetorical question, anecdote, appeal to tradition, inclusive "we")**. Key figures: **Swift, Johnson, Truss, Humphrys, Heffer, Gwynne (prescriptive); Crystal, Aitchison, Cameron, Labov, Milroy (descriptive)**.